# Ice, cranes and quiet coasts

A February route through Sounkyo, the Tokachi coast and the Kushiro wetlands, built from scratch around daylight, road conditions and the few weeks when the ice appears.



| DATES (EXAMPLE) | TRAVELERS | GETTING AROUND | IN / OUT |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Feb 10 – 14, 2027** | **2 adults** | **Rental car*** | **Asahikawa → Kushiro** |

## The route at a glance · tap a day to jump to it

| Day | Where | Highlight | Driving (winter) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Day 1 | Asahikawa Airport → Sounkyo | Ice Fall Festival at night | about 1 h 45 min |
| Day 2 | Sounkyo → Mikuni Pass → Obihiro | Pass crossed in daylight | about 3 – 3.5 h |
| Day 3 | Obihiro → Tokachi coast → Kushiro | Jewelry ice at sunrise (if it has washed up) | about 4 h in total |
| Day 4 | Kushiro → Tsurui → Hosooka | Red-crowned cranes, wetland sunset | about 3 h in total |
| Day 5 | Kushiro wetlands → Kushiro Airport | Wetland roads, often with deer | about 1 h |

## Why this order works

- **Mountains first, coast later:** the highest road of the trip (Mikuni Pass) is crossed on day 2 in full daylight, while you're still fresh for the longest mountain drive.
- **Sleep close enough to the coast:** Obihiro is about 1 h 15 min from the beach, so the jewelry ice sunrise (6:28) needs a 4:45 start: the ice glows best in the half hour before sunrise.
- **Made for your phone:** every stop has a map link, and the PDF works offline in areas with weak signal.
- **Car where it matters:** the coast at dawn is almost impossible by public transport. Each day also shows the train and bus option, so you can decide leg by leg.

* Driving is your decision. Winter tires come standard on Hokkaido rentals, but snowy roads need experience, and you need an International Driving Permit valid in Japan (or an official Japanese translation for some countries). If you have never driven on snow and ice, choose the bus options. Want Biei instead of Sounkyo? Swap days 1–2 for Asahikawa → Biei → Karikachi Pass → Obihiro.



## Day 1 · Asahikawa Airport → Sounkyo

Sunset 16:51

**12:00** **Pick up the rental car** near Asahikawa Airport Map One-way drop-off in Kushiro: ask the rental company about the fee.

**14:00** **Arrive in Sounkyo** CAR · 1 h 45 min Map About 1 h 45 min. Check in and rest: it gets dark before 5 pm.

**19:00** **Sounkyo Onsen Ice Fall Festival** Map Lit-up ice sculptures by the river (usually late Jan – early Mar). Walk from the hotel area; no driving at night.

**By bus:** airport bus to Asahikawa Station (about 35 min), then Dohoku Bus to Sounkyo (about 2 h). A good option: about 2 h 45 min including the transfer.

## Day 2 · Sounkyo → Mikuni Pass → Obihiro

Sunset 16:52

**7:30** **Check road status** MUST Route 273 over Mikuni Pass can close in blizzards. Check the Hokkaido road information site the night before and in the morning.

**9:00** **Leave Sounkyo** CAR · 3 – 3.5 h Map About 3 – 3.5 h to Obihiro with a coffee stop. Fill up with fuel before the pass: there are few stations.

**13:00** **Obihiro** Map Late lunch, then an early night. Tomorrow starts at 4:45.

**If the pass is closed:** drive back via Asahikawa and Karikachi Pass (much longer, about 4.5 h). **By public transport:** bus back to Asahikawa, then the Northliner bus via Karikachi Pass to Obihiro (the Furano–Shintoku rail line closed in 2024). Plan on most of the day.



## Day 3 · Tokachi coast at sunrise → Kushiro

Sunrise 6:28 · Sunset 16:49

**4:45** **Leave Obihiro** CAR · 1 h 15 min About 1 h 15 min in the dark. Watch for ice on the road and deer.

**6:28** **Jewelry ice at Otsu Beach** Map Clear ice washed up on the sand, usually mid-January to late February. Some years it barely appears: check local news the day before. Please leave the ice on the beach.

**8:00** **Harunire Tree** CAR · 30 min Map About 30 min. The famous elm in soft morning light, with few people.

**11:30** **Kushiro** CAR · 2.5 h Map About 2.5 h. Seafood lunch at the market, then rest.

**By public transport:** the coast at dawn is not realistic. A local tour or taxi from Obihiro is the practical way. The Harunire Tree is about 30 min (2.2 km) on foot from JR Toyokoro Station.



## Day 4 · Cranes and a wetland sunset

Sunset 16:50

**6:30** **Otowa Bridge, Tsurui** CAR · 1 h Map About 1 h from Kushiro. On cold, clear mornings, cranes leave their river roost in the mist. Stay quiet, no flash, and don't park on the road.

**9:30** **Tsurumidai** Map Cranes gather in the snowy field (Nov – Mar). Stay behind the fence, keep your voice down and never feed the cranes. Late morning in Tsurui or Kushiro.

**14:30** **Back for the feeding** Feeding is usually around 14:30. Bird flu can close or delay it: check with Tsurui Village before you go.

**16:10** **Hosooka Observation Deck** CAR · 1 h Map About 1 h from Tsurui (leave around 15:00). Sunset over the Kushiro Wetland at 16:50. The visitor lounge closes at 16:00 in winter.

**17:10** **Back to Kushiro** CAR · 40 min AFTER DARK About 40 min on main roads. Not comfortable driving at night? Visit Hosooka at midday instead.

**By public transport:** Akan Bus from Kushiro Station to Tsurumidai (about 1 h, few departures a day). Hosooka is about 10–15 min uphill on foot from JR Kushiro-Shitsugen Station, but winter trains are few: check the last train before planning the sunset.



## Day 5 · Wetland morning → home

Sunrise 6:23

**8:00** **Slow drive on the wetland roads** Sika deer often stand in the reeds in the morning. Pull over only where it is safe.

**11:30** **Return the car at Kushiro Airport** Map Allow time to clear snow from the car and refuel.

## Booking list

| What | When to book | Note |
|---|---|---|
| Rental car (Asahikawa → Kushiro) | As soon as dates are set | Ask about the one-way fee and winter equipment |
| Stay in Sounkyo | Early | Festival season; walking distance to the venue helps |
| A local sunrise tour (if not driving) | 2 – 4 weeks before | I can list the types, not book them. Depends on ice conditions |

## If the weather turns

- **Blizzard warning:** don't drive. Swap the day with a rest day in town, or move by train where it runs.
- **No jewelry ice:** stay for the sunrise anyway, then spend more time at the Harunire Tree and the Tokachi River mouth.
- **Cranes not at the field:** wait for the afternoon feeding, or check other viewing spots in Tsurui.



Hosooka Observation Deck, day 4: the wetland just after sunset.

I don't book anything or choose specific hotels. Road and train conditions change in winter, so please recheck them the day before and on the morning of each drive.